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Unit 10 : Tee Ball

Young children have difficulty hitting a moving ball when they first learn how to play baseball. It is also hard to find a pitcher in this age group who can consistently throw the ball across the plate with any speed or accuracy—not to mention a catcher with enough coordination to catch a fast moving ball. Real baseball is just too difficult and a bit too dangerous for youngsters.

To solve these problems tee ball was created. Parents no longer had to fear that their six year old would be hit by a wild pitch and spectators no longer had to endure extremely boring games where hits were about as rare as a boiled potato in a Taiwanese restaurant. It also made the game a lot more enjoyable for kids who weren't athletic enough to otherwise play.

Tee ball is basically baseball where there is no pitching. Just like the real game there are 3 bases and a home plate. The positions are the same, too. There are 3 outfielders, 3 basemen, a short stop, a “pitcher” (he doesn't actually pitch), and a catcher. Outfielders don't tend to see a lot of action though because small children can't hit the ball very far.

A large tee holds the ball in place at home plate. The tee can be moved up or down, depending on the height of the hitter, to make sure that the ball is always in his or her hitting zone. The ball is in play once it is struck and leaves the tee. At this point the game is played just like regular baseball. Even though the ball is motionless, it is surprising how many children still have a tough time hitting it. They often hit the

tee itself and the ball just drops right to the ground.

Organized tee ball leagues are quite common, but not overly competitive. Children usually start when they are 5 or 6 years old and play for 2 or so seasons. Once their skills have developed enough to play real baseball, they can move on.

The game is good for developing fundamentals and learning the rules of baseball. Although some children may never make the cut on a real baseball team when they are finished, at least they've had the chance to have fun and get a taste of something that they might not have otherwise had the chance to.